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JAI JAGANNATH Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan (middle) at a roadshow in Nilgiri, May 27

BJP	CONG	BJD	OTHERS
2024 Lok Sabha *[Total seats 21]*			
20 (45.4%)	**1** (12.5%)	**0** (37.5%)	–
2024 Assembly *[Total seats 147]*			
78 (40%)	**14** (13.3%)	**51** (40.2%)	**4** (6.5%)

Vote share in ( )

or unlocking the gates of Srimandir [Jagannath Temple in Puri] or procuring paddy at Rs 3,100 per quintal, work on these will begin soon." But before delivering on these fronts, picking the chief minister will be a crucial task at hand for the party. While multiple names are doing the rounds, former Union minister and Sambalpur MP Dharmendra Pradhan is one of the likeliest choices. But at a time when the BJP is short of a clear majority at the Centre, Prime Minister Narendra Modi might not want to let go of a crucial parliamentary colleague. While comptroller and auditor general Girish Chandra Murmu's name is adding grist to the rumour mill, primarily because of his proximity to Modi, many think it is unlikely that the party will put a former IAS officer at the helm of the state when it flayed the BJD for "turning Odisha into a bureaucrat-state". There is also a chance that the party will settle for a lesser-known face. In that case, Suresh Pujari could be their bet. The former MP and state party chief has been elected to the assembly from Brajarajnagar in western Odisha, a region that voted decisively for a change. This may not be lost on the BJP top brass, say experts.

On the other hand, an existential crisis of sorts stares at the 27-year-old BJD. "The question is whether the party will survive after this defeat. Naveen Babu is too old and unwell to engineer a revival. The BJP will definitely try to break it," says Sahu. Sources in Bhubaneswar's power corridors are apprehensive about the new government's potentially vindictive approach against the previous regime. The fact that several BJD leaders were allegedly mired in corruption, including in the Seashore chit fund and mining scams, may come in handy for the BJP government. Given the saffron party's reported track record of using probe agencies to hound Opposition leaders until they are forced to bend their knee, there is speculation that the new government will use the police to force the BJD and Congress MLAs to make the switch. Moreover, three top officials in the chief minister's office, considered close to Tamil Nadu-born V.K. Pandian, Naveen's closest aide and IAS officer-turned-BJD leader, have resigned signalling a significant reshuffle in the state bureaucracy. That Pandian was his party's only visible face along with Naveen helped the BJP harp on the Odia *asmita* (pride) during the polls.

Moreover, one lingering question yet to be addressed is Naveen's level of comfort on the Opposition bench. Having been thrust into politics at 51 after his father's passing, the departing CM has remained in power consistently for 24 years. Initially a minister at the Centre, Naveen has governed Odisha since 2000. However, over the past five years, particularly since the onset of Covid-19, his presence in the legislative assembly and secretariat has been rare. He often opted for remote participation via live video links. This decision may well have cost Naveen in what many speculate may be his final election. ■